

The Product Lifecycle

Instructions:

Use this tool to get ideas about where your product is in its lifecycle and when A/B tests will be valuable to you.

Lifecycle Phase	Data-driven or vision-driven?
1. Early development	Early in the product development lifecycle, you are seeking product-market fit. Product-market fit means you have clearly defined your target customer, you have delivered a solution that they value, and your customer base is growing. Before you reach product-market fit, A/B tests may not be a great use of time. You don't have many users so your tests are unlikely to be statistically significant. Also, you're focused on fundamentals and building out core functionality. This means you won't have much time for polishing and micro-optimizations. Therefore you may use A/B tests during this phase, but they won't be your main tool. A lot of your work will be more subjective, driven by your vision and general customer feedback.
2. Scaling and optimization	Once you reach product-market fit, it's time to optimize. At this point you still have fundamentals and vision to work on, but your key responsibility is to tune your rocket ship so it's pointed in exactly the right direction. When you are scaling at high velocity, optimizations produce huge results. A/B tests are a great tool to deploy during this phase, as long as you're smart about where to use them.
3. Mature product	After you reach critical scale, your pace of growth will naturally slow. At this point, you hit an interesting balance. You know exactly how and where you can optimize your current product. However, tech cycles come every 3-5 years and sometimes even faster. You will need to strike a balance between A/B tests that drive short-term results and exploratory work that will help you find the next big opportunity.

